

SEEKING A REMEDY SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal at a 'Punjab Bachao' rally in Ghanour, Aug. 30

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The Loneliness of Sukhbir Badal

The Akali scion's chances of a political rebirth hinge on difficult seat-sharing talks with the BJP. Problem is, he has little to bargain with

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

HE ENDURED A KIRPAN ATTACK SIX weeks ago, the second attempt on his life in 20 months. His party has exactly one MP, and one MLA he can count on. Sikh institutions his party used to control are battling the credibility crisis as well. And the thought of political survival is goading him to court a former ally that has spent two years depleting his infantry: the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has based a part of its growth strategy on recruiting his father's men and his extended kin. In the autumn of 2026, barely five months before an assembly election, the loneliness of Sukhbir Badal awaits only a test of his long-distance running.

To be fair, on paper the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) has three MLAs. One, Ganieve Majithia, is core family. Another, Dr Sukhwinder Singh Sukhi, joined the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in 2024. But the third one is out campaigning for the radical side: Amritpal Singh's Akali faction, Waris Punjab De. On September 27, Sukhbir turned his fire on Manpreet Singh Ayali, MLA from Dakha. Ayali led the SAD in the assembly till June. And here he was, being threatened by the man who is technically still his boss—Ayali would be behind bars, after an inquiry, if Sukhbir could have his way. Earlier this month, Sukhbir was even heard accusing chief minister Bhagwant Mann of planting Ayali in Amritpal's camp to split the panth.

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If such is the state of his soldiery, the panthic moat that once secured the Akalis is in need of serious repair. Sukhbir's only consolation is that Mann, who recently went eye to eye with the religious establishment himself, is not much placed much higher on that ladder. Except that, as CM, he has scope to redeem things through the legislative route. Indeed, Punjab's panthic universe was busy that Sunday, and the Akalis were nowhere in the picture. Mann was ensconced with a seven-member panel to rework the anti-sacrilege law the Akal Takht has ordered him to amend. The only Sukhbir connection: panel member Giani Raghbir Singh, the jathedar who had declared him *tankhaiya* (guilty of religious misconduct) in 2024.

This is the broad lay of the land that has led Sukhbir to tilt back towards the BJP, six years after the SAD walked out of a 24-year-old marriage with the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) over the farm bills. On August 7, he spent about 20 minutes with PM Narendra Modi in Parliament House. The next day, the SAD declared its support for the Delimitation Bill. Many veterans believe an alliance with the BJP is a tactical necessity for survival. Most importantly, it could restore the confi-